

I. THE CHRISTIAN AND ALCOHOL

I realize the subject I am dealing with today is controversial in Christian circles and will likely be controversial in this setting as well. All I ask is for each of you to hear me out with an open mind and search the scriptures I am going to share with you, as well as the line of reasoning I will follow. Traditionally, the stance of the protestant church in America has been that of total abstinence. In recent years many have come to question our stance, and when we did not furnish a satisfactory answer to why we take that stand, they assume there is no good reason to abide by these traditional values. Allow me to begin by saying that I believe total abstinence is the boundary a Christian should set with regard to alcohol consumption.

Those who believe we should soften, readjust, or erase this very important boundary, will almost always say, *“The Word of God is not clear on where the boundary should be set.”* I must admit, even though my personal stand as well as my theological stand has always been total abstinence, I was a bit intimidated to join the discussion because I had never really studied this subject in depth. That has changed; I have conducted a thorough study of the subject which has spanned several months and I am going to attempt to share the results of my research with you over the next couple of Sundays. My study will cover the theological position as well as the cultural effects of this issue.

Let’s look at what the Scripture has to say concerning alcohol consumption:

- The Lord speaks to Moses concerning the vow of a Nazarite... Numbers 6:1-4 (KJV) *“And the LORD spake unto Moses, saying, ²Speak unto the children of Israel, and say unto them, When either man or woman shall separate themselves to vow a vow of a Nazarite, to separate themselves unto the LORD: ³He shall separate himself from wine and strong drink, and shall drink no vinegar of wine, or vinegar of strong drink, neither shall he drink any liquor of grapes, nor eat moist grapes, or dried. ⁴All the days of his separation shall he eat nothing that is made of the vine tree, from the kernels even to the husk.”* The vow of the Nazarite was constructed to make sure the individual being separated as a Nazarite would be an example to all Israelites of the highest standard of holiness in their commitment to God as well as their lifestyle. According to God’s clear instructions, a Nazarite was to abstain completely from *“wine and strong drink.”* The warning was so strong that the Nazarite was instructed not to consume any product made from the grape or grapevine either in

liquid or solid form. Most likely God gave this command as a safeguard against the temptation to use intoxicating drinks and against the possibility of a Nazarite drinking alcoholic wine by mistake. God did not want any totally devoted person to be exposed to the possibility of intoxication or addiction, even unknowingly. If God was so strict with the Nazarite that they could not even touch any product derived from the vine, then His highest call to the believer is that of total abstinence. Complete consecration to God and His standards of holiness is something Christians should emulate on a free will basis. Every believer should avoid anything which has the potential of drawing us into sin; stimulating a desire for harmful things; place us in a compromising position; dull our decision making ability; cause a brother or sister to stumble; or open the door to drug or alcohol addiction.

- The Lord speaks to the Children of Israel... and say's in Deuteronomy 29:5-6 (KJV) ***"I have led you forty years in the wilderness: your clothes are not waxen old upon you, and thy shoe is not waxen old upon thy foot. ⁶Ye have not eaten bread, neither have ye drunk wine or strong drink: that ye might know that I am the LORD your God."***
- Solomon, the wisest man ever addresses our subject... Proverbs 20:1 (KJV) ***"Wine is a mocker, strong drink is raging: and whosoever is deceived thereby is not wise."***
- Solomon speaks out again on this topic... Proverbs 23:29-35 (KJV) ***"Who hath woe? who hath sorrow? who hath contentions? Who hath babbling? who hath wounds without cause? who hath redness of eyes? ³⁰ They that tarry long at the wine; they that go to seek mixed wine. ³¹ Look not thou upon the wine when it is red, when it giveth his colour in the cup, when it moveth itself aright."*** These verses contain clear instruction regarding abstinence from alcoholic drink. The Hebrew verb used for the phrase ***"When it is red"*** is ***"yith'addam"*** literally means ***"When it is made red"*** and directly points to the color of fermented wine. ***"³² At the last it biteth like a serpent, and stingeth like an adder."*** This passage describes the addictive effects of fermented wine. Alcohol can be demonic and destructive, resulting in physical ailments, blurred vision, lack of judgment, a confused mind, and a loose tongue. Consuming even one alcoholic drink leads to some impairment of a person's motor skills and ability to make sound judgments. Continued use opens one's life to intoxication and addiction with all their harmful consequences physically, socially, spiritually and morally. The only way to be sure

one will not end up this way is to avoid all intoxicating beverages. *“³⁴Thine eyes shall behold strange women, and thine heart shall utter perverse things. ³⁴Yea, thou shalt be as he that lieth down in the midst of the sea, or as he that lieth upon the top of a mast. ³⁵They have stricken me, shalt thou say, and I was not sick; they have beaten me, and I felt it not: when shall I awake? I will seek it yet again.”*

- Solomon’s Mother weighs in on the subject... Proverbs 31:4-6 (KJV) *“It is not for kings, O Lemuel, it is not for kings to drink wine; nor for princes strong drink: ⁵Lest they drink, and forget the law, and pervert the judgment of any of the afflicted. ⁶Give strong drink unto him that is ready to perish, and wine unto those that be of heavy hearts. ⁷Let him drink, and forget his poverty, and remember his misery no more.”*
- The prophet Isaiah speaks rather clearly and at length about the effects of this dangerous substance... Isaiah 5:11:15 (KJV) *“Woe unto them that rise up early in the morning, that they may follow strong drink; that continue until night, till wine inflame them! ¹²And the harp, and the viol, the tabret, and pipe, and wine, are in their feasts: but they regard not the work of the LORD, neither consider the operation of his hands. ¹³Therefore my people are gone into captivity, because they have no knowledge: and their honourable men are famished, and their multitude dried up with thirst. ¹⁴Therefore hell hath enlarged herself, and opened her mouth without measure: and their glory, and their multitude, and their pomp, and he that rejoiceth, shall descend into it. ¹⁵And the mean man shall be brought down, and the mighty man shall be humbled, and the eyes of the lofty shall be humbled.”* Isaiah 24:5-12 (KJV) *“The earth also is defiled under the inhabitants thereof; because they have transgressed the laws, changed the ordinance, broken the everlasting covenant. ⁶Therefore hath the curse devoured the earth, and they that dwell therein are desolate: therefore the inhabitants of the earth are burned, and few men left. ⁷The new wine mourneth, the vine languisheth, all the merryhearted do sigh. ⁸The mirth of tabrets ceaseth, the noise of them that rejoice endeth, the joy of the harp ceaseth. ⁹They shall not drink wine with a song; strong drink shall be bitter to them that drink it. ¹⁰The city of confusion is broken down: every house is shut up, that no man may come in. ¹¹There is a crying for wine in the streets; all joy is darkened, the mirth of the land is gone. ¹²In the city is left desolation, and the gate is smitten*

with destruction.” Isaiah 28:1-8 (KJV) “Woe to the crown of pride, to the drunkards of Ephraim, whose glorious beauty is a fading flower, which are on the head of the fat valleys of them that are overcome with wine! ²Behold, the Lord hath a mighty and strong one, which as a tempest of hail and a destroying storm, as a flood of mighty waters overflowing, shall cast down to the earth with the hand. ³The crown of pride, the drunkards of Ephraim, shall be trodden under feet: ⁴And the glorious beauty, which is on the head of the fat valley, shall be a fading flower, and as the hasty fruit before the summer; which when he that looketh upon it seeth, while it is yet in his hand he eateth it up. ⁵In that day shall the LORD of hosts be for a crown of glory, and for a diadem of beauty, unto the residue of his people, ⁶And for a spirit of judgment to him that sitteth in judgment, and for strength to them that turn the battle to the gate. ⁷But they also have erred through wine, and through strong drink are out of the way; the priest and the prophet have erred through strong drink, they are swallowed up of wine, they are out of the way through strong drink; they err in vision, they stumble in judgment. ⁸For all tables are full of vomit and filthiness, so that there is no place clean.” Isaiah 56:10-12 (KJV) “His watchmen are blind: they are all ignorant, they are all dumb dogs, they cannot bark; sleeping, lying down, loving to slumber. ¹¹Yea, they are greedy dogs which can never have enough, and they are shepherds that cannot understand: they all look to their own way, every one for his gain, from his quarter. ¹²Come ye, say they, I will fetch wine, and we will fill ourselves with strong drink; and to morrow shall be as this day, and much more abundant.” William Shakespeare said, “O God, that men should put an enemy in their mouths to steal away their brains! That we should with joy, pleasance, revel, and applause, transform ourselves into beasts!”

- Paul enlightens the Romans with regard to the subject of alcohol consumption... Romans 14:20-23 (NKJV) “***Do not destroy the work of God for the sake of food. All things indeed are pure, but it is evil for the man who eats with offense. ²¹It is good neither to eat meat nor drink wine nor do anything by which your brother stumbles or is offended or is made weak. ²²Do you have faith? Have it to yourself before God. Happy is he who does not condemn himself in what he approves. ²³But he who doubts is condemned if he eats, because he does not eat from faith; for whatever is not from faith is sin.***”

- Paul warns his understudy, Timothy, about the evils of alcohol... 1 Timothy 3:2-10 (NKJV) ***“A bishop then must be blameless, the husband of one wife, temperate, sober-minded, of good behavior, hospitable, able to teach; ³not given to wine, not violent, not greedy for money, but gentle, not quarrelsome, not covetous; ⁴one who rules his own house well, having his children in submission with all reverence ⁵(for if a man does not know how to rule his own house, how will he take care of the church of God?); ⁶not a novice, lest being puffed up with pride he fall into the same condemnation as the devil. ⁷Moreover he must have a good testimony among those who are outside, lest he fall into reproach and the snare of the devil. ⁸Likewise deacons must be reverent, not double-tongued, not given to much wine, not greedy for money, ⁹holding the mystery of the faith with a pure conscience. ¹⁰But let these also first be tested; then let them serve as deacons, being found blameless.”*** Paul said the same thing to Titus in Titus 1:8 that he said to Timothy here, ***“Not given to wine.”*** Then when he is speaking to Titus with regard to the women in the church (Titus 2:3) he uses the phrase ***“Not given to much wine.”***
- Paul, talking to Timothy as well as some other church leaders makes this alarming statement... in 1 Timothy 5:23 (NKJV) ***“No longer drink only water, but use a little wine for your stomach’s sake and your frequent infirmities.”*** Some well-meaning people have misused the instruction given by Paul to Timothy; he was not suggesting that Timothy begin drinking socially or responsibly! As a result of some illnesses Timothy was obviously struggling with, Paul suggest he consider wine only for medicinal purposes. After studying this at great length I am quite sure the wine Paul is referring to here was unfermented. It is generally believed that Timothy normally did not drink wine of any kind, fermented or unfermented, which is why Paul gives him special permission to do so for medicinal purposes. According to Greek writings on medicine, wine used for the “stomachs sake” was more than likely unfermented and thus not intoxicating. Athenaeus states, *“Let him take sweet wine, either mixed with water or warmed, especially that kind called protropos (juice coming from the grapes before they are pressed), as being good for the stomach, for sweet wine (oinos) does not make the head heavy.”* (Athenaeus, Banquet, 2:24) Based on significant research of ancient Greek writers I think is unlikely that Paul was condoning the moderate or responsible use of intoxicating wine for medicinal

purposes for Timothy and church leaders. In my opinion, it is far more likely that Paul was advising the use of unfermented wine for health reasons. One must understand that one of the few beverages available in Bible times was grape juice or fermented wine. It is almost certain that the first century Apostles practiced total abstinence with regard to the fruit of the vine, whether fermented or unfermented. Paul knew that if the ministers began the practice of using unfermented wine it could very easily serve as a gateway to thinking the consumption of fermented wine was an acceptable practice for ministerial and church leaders. Therefore he says to Timothy, ***“Use a little wine for the stomach’s sake.”*** While I do not believe Paul was giving Timothy, or anyone else permission to use fermented wine for medicinal purposes, let’s just say for the sake of argument that he was. There is quite a difference between taking cough medicine, which contains alcohol and drinking socially or responsibly because one wants to drink alcohol! In Timothy’s culture medicine and doctors were not what they are today. In this culture I see no real benefit for one to consume wine or alcohol for medicinal purposes, or for any other reason! Some people say they are doing it for health purposes, when the fact is, studies have shown that a glass of pure grape juice will do medicinally, what a glass of wine will! The fact that Paul had to mention the medicinal use of wine indicates rather strongly that Timothy was committed to abstinence as a lifestyle.

The Word of God records several tragic events which can be tied directly to alcohol consumption:

- Noah... Noah saved his family from a flood that destroyed the world! If that were the end of the story, it would be a tremendous testimony! As Paul Harvey used to say, *“The rest of the story”* is not so terrific! While under the influence of alcohol Noah embarrassed himself by exposing himself to his sons. He not only brought a reproach upon himself, he embarrassed his entire family and sinned against God! The results of Noah’s actions were disastrous! (Genesis 9:20-27). I submit to you that if Noah had not consumed alcohol he would never have had such an ominous mark on his character! Take the alcohol out of this scenario and you have a true hero! Include the stimulus of alcohol and you have a one-time hero, gone bad! Why run the risk?
- Lot... Lot was a guy who already had enough problems without introducing alcohol into his family situation. His wife was so intoxicated with the lifestyle of the sodomites that she could not resist

disobeying a direct command from God; she discovered that she was turning into a salt block while looking back to an extraordinarily sinful city! She wanted to return to Sodom, but she woke up dead instead! Following his wife's untimely death, Lot was left to raise two daughters as a single father. His daughters served him liquor until he became drunk; once intoxicated, Lot parts with all reason and sensibility, and commits incest with his daughters! (Genesis 19:30-38). Bertrand Russell said, "*Drunkenness is temporary suicide.*"

- Xerxes... This powerful King ruled over a great kingdom and had a beautiful wife. Though he was intelligent enough to lead a Kingdom successfully, once intoxicated, he could not hold his liquor nor his own marriage together! Xerxes allowed his mouth to override his sense of reason, all because of the effects of alcohol. While under the influence, he commanded his wife to do things she was not willing to do, and when she refused, in order to keep the other ladies in the Kingdom from rebelling against their husbands, it became necessary for Xerxes to depose the queen and find another. (Esther 1:9-22) This was not the first, nor the last marriage to be ended because of the evils of alcohol!
- Belshazzar... While in a drunken stupor, this otherwise intellectually brilliant King committed sacrilege with the sacred vessels from the Jewish temple. The judgment of God was swift and stern! That very night he was killed as a fulfillment of prophecy (Daniel 5). If God would kill a man for drinking alcohol out of the consecrated vessels from the Old Testament Temple, what do you think His opinion of placing the same thing in a vessel which is a "*Temple of the Holy Ghost*" would be?

Proverbs 22:28 (NKJV) "**Do not remove the ancient landmark
Which your fathers have set.**"

Proverbs 23:10-11 (NKJV) "**Do not remove the ancient landmark,
Nor enter the fields of the fatherless; ¹¹ For their Redeemer is
mighty; He will plead their cause against you.**"

Hosea 5:10 (NKJV) "**The princes of Judah are like those who
remove a landmark; I will pour out my wrath on them like water.**"

In the Old Testament the Tabernacle or Temple was a physical building. Under grace the abiding place of God is in human beings rather than a physical building. 1 Corinthians 6:19-20 (KJV) "**Know ye not that your**

body is the temple of the Holy Ghost which is in you, which ye have of God, and ye are not your own? ²⁰For ye are bought with a price: therefore glorify God in your body, and in your spirit, which are God's.

Look at what the Angel said to Zacharias at the announcement of the birth of John the Baptist. Luke 1:15-16 (NKJV) ***“For he will be great in the sight of the Lord, and shall drink neither wine nor strong drink. He will also be filled with the Holy Spirit, even from his mother’s womb. ¹⁶“And he will turn many of the children of Israel to the Lord their God.”***

In the Old Testament the Levites who were the spiritual leaders of the people were instructed to maintain a position of total abstinence from wine or intoxicating drink. Leviticus 10:8-11: (NKJV) ***“Then the LORD spoke to Aaron, saying: Do not drink wine or intoxicating drink ⁹“, you, nor your sons with you, when you go into the tabernacle of meeting, lest you die. It shall be a statute forever throughout your generations, ¹⁰“that you may distinguish between holy and unholy, and between unclean and clean, ¹¹“and that you may teach the children of Israel all the statutes which the LORD has spoken to them by the hand of Moses.”*** This requirement of abstinence was given so the judgment of the ministering priest would not be impaired by outside influences. The Lord wanted the priests to be at their best while ministering to and for the people.

Under the dispensation of grace all born-again believers are Kings and Priests unto God. 1 Peter 2:9 (NKJV) ***“But you are a chosen generation, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, His own special people, that you may proclaim the praises of Him who called you out of darkness into His marvelous light; ¹⁰who once were not a people but are now the people of God, who had not obtained mercy but now have obtained mercy.”***

Revelation 1:5-6 (NKJV) ***“To Him who loved us and washed us from our sins in His own blood, ⁶and has made us kings and priests to His God and Father, to Him be glory and dominion forever and ever. Amen.”***

If our bodies are the temple of the Holy Ghost and we are all functioning as Kings and Priests should we not be careful about intentionally allowing outside influences to impair our judgment?

It should go without saying that the standard of abstinence demanded of the Old Testament Priest should be the standard of every contemporary Christian. The Christian community has a breathtaking responsibility to lead its culture to Christ, and indulging in something that is wreaking havoc on

the society we are attempting to win, hardly seems plausible. As believers, we have a responsibility to do all we can to set a Godly example and display righteous conduct. I hardly think alcohol consumption comes close to a Godly example or righteous conduct.

For all of those who would say that believers are not the Priests but the vocational ministers are the Priests let me remind you that the Word of God speaks out against the use of alcohol among civic leaders! Proverbs 31:4-5 (KJV) ***"It is not for kings, O Lemuel, it is not for kings to drink wine; nor for princes strong drink: ⁵Lest they drink, and forget the law, and pervert the judgment of any of the afflicted."*** If those who are leading the secular world have a responsibility to stay away from such an impairing substance it should follow that Christians are held to a higher standard than those who are not Christians.

How much alcohol is too much? Proverbs 23:29-32 (KJV) ***"Who hath woe? who hath sorrow? who hath contentions? Who hath babbling? who hath wounds without cause? who hath redness of eyes? ³⁰They that tarry long at the wine; they that go to seek mixed wine. ³¹Look not thou upon the wine when it is red, when it giveth his colour in the cup, when it moveth itself aright. ³²At the last it biteth like a serpent, and stingeth like an adder."***

By medical definition, alcohol is a drug! If a little alcohol consumption is alright where is the line? Is the line the same for everyone? By rejecting the stance of total abstinence are we opening the door of destruction to those who cannot handle it? Are we placing people who are predisposed to alcohol abuse in a vulnerable position by needlessly setting the example of responsible alcohol consumption? Is it worth the risk? Mark Twain said, *"Sometimes too much drink is barely enough."*

Without question there have been too many heated arguments on this subject and it is not my intention to start another one, it is my intention to tell you everything I know and let you make your own decision.

I want to present one more Scriptural angle on this subject by asking and answering three basic questions:

- When the Bible mentions ***"wine"*** is it always referring to an alcoholic drink as it is in our culture? Many Bible scholars and theologians agree that there were many different kinds of wine in the Bible; some

believe there may have been as many as 150 varieties of wine. I know this, the Hebrew language has nine different words which are translated wine in the Old Testament and the Greek employs four different words, which are merged into one word in the King James Version of the New Testament. Some people take an extreme position and say that what the Bible is speaking of is never alcoholic in content. That is absurd and cannot be successfully defended by Scripture or history! Another indefensible view is that all wine mentioned in the Bible was alcoholic. Bible scholars tell us that when strong drink or wine is mentioned in the Bible that in some cases it is speaking of a fermented beverage; at other times when wine is mentioned it is either unfermented or mixed in such a diluted form that it would be impossible to get drunk no matter how much one consumed, as the body would get rid of it more quickly than one could drink it. Those who hold to the view of all wine in the Bible being non alcoholic do so without regard to theology or history. Those who believe all wine in the Bible was alcoholic assume that since refrigeration was unavailable in the warm Mediterranean climate, there was no way of preserving the fruit of the vine in an unfermented state. This view ignores evidence from ancient writers such as Pliny (Natural History 14.11) and Columella (De re rustica 12.29) who describe the production of non-alcoholic wine known as *aigloukos* (*I-glukos*) which means always sweet. The practice for preserving wine in a non-alcoholic state for long periods of time was to boil the fresh grape juice down to about a third of its original volume. The result would be that the condensed juice would then become very sweet, and because of its high sugar content, it both resisted spoilage and did not easily ferment. Later, water could be added back to produce reconstituted juice. In its condensed form, the juice could be used as a sweetener both in cooking and in the production of other wines. Unfermented juice was also used as a medicine. The process which I have just mentioned could be taken a little farther and the juice could be boiled down a little more and the grape juice could then be made into syrups and jellies. The juice, in its condensed form, could also be used as preservatives. Fresh fruit such as pears, for instance, were often packed in grape syrup or in honey to keep them from spoiling (see Columella, De re rustica 12.10 and Cato, De agricultura7).

- How does the alcoholic content in ancient fermented wine compare with that of the various wines today? In the Bible, sweet wines were generally non-alcoholic, and were hugely popular in the ancient

world, since there were not many options beyond water. Because fermentation automatically, chemically, reduces the natural sugars found in grape juice to alcohol; alcoholic wines contain less sugar than unfermented grape juice; thus it is believed that most **“sweet wine”** or **“best wine”** mentioned in the Bible were non-alcoholic in composition. As already stated the most common method of developing sweet wine was to boil juice down and then later add water to reconstitute it. This practice accounts for many, if not all, of the references to **“mixed wine”** in ancient writing. At other times, water was added in order to dilute fermented wine. This was probably done to reduce its percentage of alcohol or simply to make it go further. Sometimes spices, perfumes and resins were added to wine to change and enhance its flavor. The typical concoction for mixing wine in order to dilute its alcoholic content; change its flavor; or make it go further was three parts water to one part wine. A three-to-one ratio is explicitly mentioned in both Hesiod (Works and days 596) and the Talmud (b. Pesachim 108b). Sometimes in the ancient world, as in modern times, alcoholic wine was consumed in order to become intoxicated. As a rule of thumb, wine was used as an ordinary beverage, not as an intoxicant, and was diluted with water. In our culture, a typical fermented wine has an alcoholic content of about 14 percent which is the point at which the alcohol kills off the yeast and terminates fermentation. Alcoholic wine, mixed at a three-to-one ratio, results in a beverage with a 3.5 percent alcoholic content, which is only mildly intoxicating and then only if a large quantity is consumed. Most people who consume wine or alcohol are not even mildly interested in a drink with a 3.5 percent alcoholic content. This means that inebriation is a much greater problem for wine drinkers today than it was in the ancient world.

- When Jesus turned water into wine at the wedding in Cana of Galilee, was the wine alcoholic or unfermented? John 2:1-10 (NKJV) ***“On the third day there was a wedding in Cana of Galilee, and the mother of Jesus was there. ²Now both Jesus and His disciples were invited to the wedding. ³And when they ran out of wine, the mother of Jesus said to Him, “They have no wine.” ⁴Jesus said to her, “Woman, what does your concern have to do with Me? My hour has not yet come.” ⁵His mother said to the servants, “Whatever He says to you, do it.” ⁶Now there were set there six waterpots of stone, according to the manner of purification of the Jews, containing twenty or thirty gallons apiece. ⁷Jesus said to them, “Fill the waterpots with water.”***

And they filled them up to the brim. ⁸ *And He said to them, “Draw some out now, and take it to the master of the feast.” And they took it.* ⁹ *When the master of the feast had tasted the water that was made wine, and did not know where it came from (but the servants who had drawn the water knew), the master of the feast called the bridegroom.* ¹⁰ *And he said to him, “Every man at the beginning sets out the good wine, and when the guests have well drunk, then the inferior. You have kept the best wine until now!”* I have always had a difficult time believing Jesus would turn water into an alcoholic beverage, which carries with it the potential of all kinds of addictions and destruction. He came to build people up, not tear them down! Most Bible Theologians would agree that in Bible times the terms “*good wine*” and “*best wine*” always refer to unfermented wine. The best wine was considered to be the wine which actually tasted the best and was fresh, unfermented juice straight from the grape press. In the King James Version as well as most other versions of the Bible the term “*wine*” is used in a very broad sense, in fact this word is used to identify both fermented and unfermented wine. So when we read our Bible and the Scripture say’s certain people drank wine, it is an inappropriate assumption to automatically presuppose they were drinking fermented wine which contained alcoholic content; it is an equally erroneous assumption to presume they were drinking unfermented wine. In order to properly ascertain which variety of wine is being used, one must do a word study and consider the entire context of Scripture in which the event is set. In order to come to a correct understanding of whether Jesus turned the water into fermented or unfermented wine one must properly understand the person and ministry of Jesus. Through His life and ministry something brand new and unprecedented was about to spring forth on the civil and spiritual canvas. While a new system of religion was imminent, the old order of Judaism was postured to reject anything new which appeared on the horizon. The six stone water jars used for Jewish ceremonial washing represent the old way of Judaism; the new wine that came forth out of the old represents the newness which would characterize the life; ministry; and the new system of religion which Jesus would establish. Jesus turned between 120 and 180 gallons of water into wine! The fact that He performed such a miracle in such a great quantity denotes the extravagant plenteousness and lavish abundance of God’s grace to us through Jesus. It is within this context of newness in the book of John that we consider the question

about the kind of wine Jesus created. Was it fermented or unfermented? Was it new wine or aged wine? It is believed that Jesus created unfermented wine rather than alcoholic wine for the following reasons:

1. Unfermented wine fits better the context of John with its emphasis on the newness of life and the newness of the gospel. Old wineskins and old wine are associated with Judaism, not the gospel. The ultimate goal of redemption is to make all things new.
2. The quality of the wine which Jesus created is called **“good** (Greek, kalon) **wine”** in contrast to **“the inferior wine.”** (v. 10). According to an assortment of ancient writers, the use of the words **“good wine”** means choice or best wine. In the setting of that culture the terminology which was employed was immediately recognizable as the sweetest wine, or unfermented wine. It is rather obvious in this Scripture that the wine which Jesus created had not had its sugar content destroyed through the process known as fermentation. According to historical terminology, the **“inferior wine”** was alcoholic wine. Unlike the present culture, in antiquity, wine was not thought to improve with age. This is because there was always the danger of the wine souring, or turning to vinegar which is known in history as **“sour wine.”** The banquet master implies the traditional method would be to serve the **“best wine”** (Unfermented) first, and the **“inferior wine”** (Fermented) last. This man is saying, *“We served the best wine we had first and followed it with the inferior wine, but what you have provided is far better than our best wine!”* There is strong Scriptural evidence that Jesus turned the 180 gallons of water at the wedding in Cana of Galilee to unfermented wine.

Let's just say for the sake of argument that drinking in moderation is not a sin. With all the risks pointed out in the Word of God and all the risks being warned of in our society, are we really willing to take the risk of departing from the stance of total abstinence?

Better yet, what if we can handle it but our children grow up believing there is nothing wrong with it, and they cannot handle it? Can we live with the knowledge that it was our lax stance on the issue that opened the door of destruction in their life? This truth is especially significant when it is applied to the young people of the world who are turning to alcohol in unprecedented numbers as an acceptable mind-altering drug. They are going beyond moderation, no matter what their parents and elders say. If Christian

parents and adults use alcohol even in moderation, just to be socially accepted, I can promise you the next generation will use it with less care and self-control. Mark Twain said, *“Water, taken in moderation, cannot hurt anybody.”*

The use of alcohol violates some basic principles laid down for all believers, whether ministers or laymen. One of these important principles is the Biblical caution not to offend a weaker brother or cause a younger Christian to fall. The best example our generation can set for the next generation is to practice and teach total abstinence. Jesus spoke very clearly to the disciples about the responsibility of the older generation to its children and youth. Luke 17:1- 2 (NKJV) ***“Then He said to the disciples, “It is impossible that no offenses should come, but woe to him through whom they do come!” “It would be better for him if a millstone were hung around his neck, and he were thrown into the sea, than that he should offend one of these little ones.”*** We must not set an example that will send others to hell and destruction.

In conclusion I want us to go back and reconsider one Scripture. Proverbs 23:29-35 (KJV) ***“Who hath woe? who hath sorrow? who hath contentions? Who hath babbling? who hath wounds without cause? who hath redness of eyes? ³⁰ They that tarry long at the wine; they that go to seek mixed wine. ³¹ Look not thou upon the wine when it is red, when it giveth his colour in the cup, when it moveth itself aright. ³² At the last it biteth like a serpent, and stingeth like an adder. ³³ Thine eyes shall behold strange women, and thine heart shall utter perverse things. ³⁴ Yea, thou shalt be as he that lieth down in the midst of the sea, or as he that lieth upon the top of a mast. ³⁵ They have stricken me, shalt thou say, and I was not sick; they have beaten me, and I felt it not: when shall I awake? I will seek it yet again.”***

No one ever purposes to become an alcoholic. Every alcoholic thought they knew where the lines were and were convinced they had enough will power to not infringe upon the limit.

If a little alcohol is good and a lot is bad, who decides where the line is? If the individual decides where the line is what keeps their judgment from being impaired by the very thing they are making a decision about?

To condone the use of alcohol is to give Satan a senseless opportunity!
Ephesians 4:24 (NKJV) ***“Do not give place to the devil.”*** The individual who refuses to have anything to do with such a dangerous taskmaster is wise indeed. Thomas Fuller said, *“A drinker has a hole under his nose that all his money runs into.”*

As we watch and pray for the return of Jesus, our senses should be as sharp and clear as they can possibly be. Luke 21:34-36 (NKJV) ***“But take heed to yourselves, lest your hearts be weighed down with carousing, drunkenness, and cares of this life, and that Day come on you unexpectedly.***³⁵***“For it will come as a snare on all those who dwell on the face of the whole earth.***³⁶***“Watch therefore, and pray always that you may be counted worthy to escape all these things that will come to pass, and to stand before the Son of Man.”***

Proverbs 22:28 (NKJV) ***“Do not remove the ancient landmark Which your fathers have set.”***

Proverbs 23:10-11 (NKJV) ***“Do not remove the ancient landmark, Nor enter the fields of the fatherless; ¹¹ For their Redeemer is mighty; He will plead their cause against you.”***

Hosea 5:10 (NKJV) ***“The princes of Judah are like those who remove a landmark; I will pour out my wrath on them like water.”***

Let's assume the Scripture was silent on this issue, look at the societal damage which is being brought upon us because of this great evil:

- Retail sales of alcohol related beverages total nearly \$120 billion dollars per year in the U.S. (U.S. Department of Agriculture)
- The average American family spends nearly \$500.00 per year on alcohol. (U.S. Bureau of Labor)
- Alcohol related crashes kill someone in the U.S. every 22 minutes. Within every minute, one of 50 drivers on the road is drunk and every weekend night, one out of 10 is drunk. (While you have sat in this service this morning, 5 people have died in alcohol related crashes) (Alcoholics Victorious)
- According to the Center for Disease Control in Atlanta, there are 105,000 alcohol related deaths annually due to drunken drivers and alcohol related injuries and diseases. (AFA journal)

- Alcohol related accidents are the leading cause of deaths among young people. (Dallas Morning Times)
- The damage caused by alcohol impaired drivers is the same as if a Boeing 747 with over 500 passengers crashed every eight days killing everyone. (Alcoholics Victorious) (If 46 Boeing 747's were crashing annually in the U.S. killing all 500 passengers aboard each plane, how many of you would want to go out to Hobby airport this afternoon and board one?)
- Drunk drivers are responsible for 1/2 of fatal highway injuries. (Alcoholics Victorious)
- An estimated 23,200 annual murders can be directly attributed to alcohol. (Newsweek)
- Of all murders, alcohol was involved in at least 34% of cases. (Alcoholics Victorious)
- More than 1/2 of rapists had been drinking. (Alcoholics Victorious)
- Mothers convicted of child abuse are 3 times more likely to be alcoholics - Fathers 10 times more likely. (Alcoholics Victorious)
- More than half of all confirmed abuse reports and 75% of child deaths involve drug or alcohol abuse on the part of the parents. (Time)
- Up to 36% of suicide victims were drinking just before ending their lives. (Prodigy Services Co.)
- Heavy drinking is involved in 60% of violent crimes, 36% of suicides, and 80% of fire and drowning accidents. (Alcoholics Victorious)
- The suicide rate of alcoholics is 30 times that of the general population. (AFA journal)
- The annual economic cost of alcohol abuse has risen to a projected \$186 billion. (Alcohol & Health - U.S. dept. of H.H.S.)
- 2.9% of 1,000 live births have fetal alcohol syndrome. (Alcoholics Victorious)
- It is costing one half billion dollars per year to treat fetal alcohol syndrome. (Alcoholics Victorious)
- It is estimated that 375,000 babies born each year are exposed to alcohol or illicit drugs parentally. (Alcoholics Victorious)
- The cost of government to prepare drug and alcohol babies to enter kindergarten has reached more than \$15 billion per year. (Reader's Digest)
- One baby with Fetal Alcohol Syndrome will cost \$405,000 in direct special services from birth to 65 years. (San Diego County Dept. of Health Services)

The consumption of alcohol has become a national crisis, tearing at the moral fabric of our nation. Thomas Fuller said, "*Wine hath drowned more men than the sea.*"

Christians cannot meet their moral responsibilities by a posture of neutrality about alcohol. The problem is not merely economic, cultural, or social. In the final analysis, the use of alcohol is a spiritual problem. Alcoholism is a sin; it is not a sickness or a disease! If it is a sickness or disease it is the only disease known to man that you must continually acquire something to keep it!

Alcoholic beverages should have no place in the life of the Christian. Let there be no doubt about where Christian Temple and this Pastor stands on this very important issue, we declare unequivocally - our conviction, that total abstinence from alcoholic beverages is the only acceptable way of life for the Christian. We call upon every member and adherent in this church to teach by word and example a life-style that totally abstains from the consumption of alcoholic beverages.